ART

Sculpting A Path

Over half a century of work will be on display at *On the Open Road*, sculptor K.S. Radhakrishnan's upcoming retrospective at Bikaner House in New Delhi

Walking through the sculptor K.S. Radhakrishnan's studio in Delhi is a heady experience. You see works from across five decades, the familiar bronze figures of Musui and Maiya (the artist's twin muses, based on a young Santhal boy who posed for him at Santiniketan) sprawled in various poses. Unfinished and assembly-required works share that space. A stray Staedtler pencil rests over the beginnings of a sketch of a pensive-looking woman.

"This is my 50th year as an artist," says Radhakrishnan. "When I began in the 1970s, I think I was a very closed person, an introvert. But gradually, if you see my work in the years after that, you can see the process of opening up. I have a large body of work now and I don't know for how long I can hold on to it, so I thought my 50th year would be a good occasion for a retrospective." The retrospective, *On the Open Road*, opens in Delhi on November 19 and will be on display at the Centre for Contemporary Art (CCA), Bikaner House, until December 14. It has been curated by art historian R. Sivakumar.

Renowned for bringing a fluidity and lightness to the bronze medium—usually associated with heft—Radhakrishnan has created a massive body of work in these 50 years. *On the Open Road* will feature some of his best-known works, like 'Freehold Musui' (Bronze, 37.7 x 83 inches, 2008) and 'Maiya as Writer' (Bronze, 76 x 42 inches, 2005), his early works from the 1970s and 1980s, as well as his latest work, 'The Crowd' (2023). 'The Crowd' consists of 50 bronze figures (25 Musuis and 25 Maiyas), each 72 inches tall, standing individually but in close proximity. This will be exhibited on the grass lawns outside the CCA gallery.





LIFELONG MUSE Freehold Maiya (top) and Freehold Musui, and (bottom) 'The Crowd' by K.S. Radhakrishnan

On his latest work, Radhakrishnan says, "This crowd is a friendly crowd. It's not one that creates fractures between people. It's about human movement, individual movements that stand out within the context of a collective. If you see the figures individually, they're all 'stepping up', their feet are on raised platforms. This represents the fact that they have individual aspirations. Together, they take on the character of a crowd: not a mob, mind you, but a crowd."

While we were talking about his lifelong devotion to Musui and Maiya, he made a parallel with genre writers who stick to one character or set of characters, often for their whole careers. Some of them eventually tire of carrying the same voice inside their head—Arthur Conan Doyle killed Sherlock Holmes off once for precisely this reason (before public outcry forced a 'resurrection'). "It can be tiring sometimes, I suppose," says Radhakrishnan. "But for me, Musui's smile was always very important. It's that smile that pushes me to keep on working, and keep telling stories through Musui and Maiya." ■

Aditya Mani Jha

On the Open Road will be on display at CCA, Bikaner House, from Nov. 19-Dec. 14

